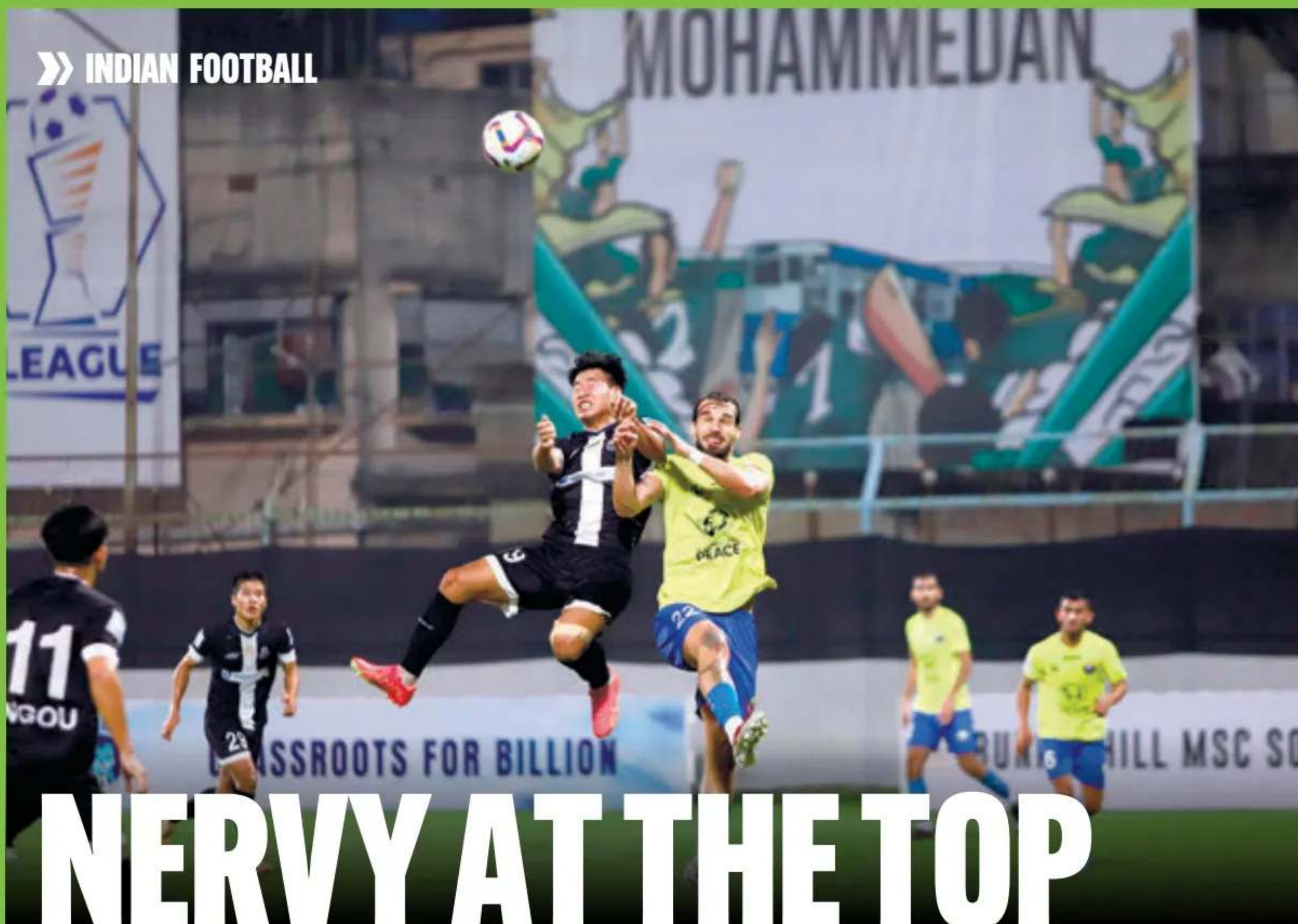




NERVY AT THE TOP

Mohammedan SC is **clinging to their lead** in the I-League, with Real Kashmir trailing just five points behind.

Aashin Prasad
aashin.p@thehindu.co.in

It hasn't been the smoothest return to competition for the I-League leader, Mohammedan SC, which lost 0-3 to Real Kashmir before it was held to a goalless draw away to Aizwal FC.

Real Kashmir, however, failed to capitalise on the slip-up by losing 0-1 to Rajasthan FC after a stoppage-time winner from Marin Mudrazija. That defeat left Kashmir trailing Mohammedan by five points at the end of 13 matches.

Third-placed Sreenidi Deccan, which has a game in hand, closed the gap at the top after its nervy 2-1 win away against Churchill Brothers. El Hadji Karim pegged Sreenidi back with an 88th-minute equaliser before a dramatic winner from Eli Sabia in the fourth minute of stoppage time lifted the side to within five points off Mohammedan.

Sreenidi's away game to NEROCA in Shillong was postponed due to operational difficulties with NEROCA likely to play the second half of

its season in the capital of Meghalaya. Bottom-placed Namdhari, Neroca and TRAU remain in the relegation berths.

Indian Women's League

Gokulam Kerala inflicted Odisha FC's first defeat of the campaign in Kozhikode in a 2-1 comeback win. Odisha got off to a perfect start thanks to a goal in the opening minute from Indumathi Kathiresan before Fazila Ikwaput scored a brace in the opening half to propel the team to the top of the table.

The defeat coupled with Kickstart's two successive wins has pushed Odisha to third in the table, with a game in hand on both Gokulam and Kickstart. At the end of nine rounds, Sports Odisha remains the only winless team in the league.

The league will now resume on March 1 as the players head off to international duties. India will participate in the Turkish Women's Cup in Alanya starting February 21.

Hot pursuit: Real Kashmir defeated Mohammedan SC 3-0 only to lose its next match and stay five points behind the league leaders. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT